

Recruiting Duplicate Management - Functional Overview

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1. Introduction to Duplicate Management in Workday Recruiting

In the Workday ecosystem, **Duplicate Management** is the critical governance layer responsible for identifying, preventing, and resolving multiple person records for the same individual. This feature is the "guardian" of data integrity. High-quality data is the non-negotiable foundation for a positive candidate experience, accurate reporting and analytics, and efficient recruiting operations.

A failure to manage duplicates introduces significant risk and operational drag. It leads to:

- **Poor Candidate Experience:** A candidate who has to re-enter the same information multiple times or who is contacted by different recruiters for the same role feels that the organization is disorganized.
- **Inaccurate Reporting:** Duplicate records skew key metrics like time-to-fill, source effectiveness, and pipeline volume, leading to poor strategic decisions.
- **Wasted Recruiter Effort:** Recruiters may spend time sourcing and engaging a candidate who is already in the pipeline under a separate record.
- **Compliance and Legal Risks:** In certain jurisdictions, maintaining multiple records with differing consent statuses can pose a compliance risk.

Workday provides two frameworks for this purpose. Understanding the distinction is vital for providing clear guidance.

- **Legacy Duplicate Management (Match & Merge):** The original, recruiting-specific framework that operates on hard-coded logic. It is no longer the leading practice and in future will be deprecated.
- **Unified Duplicate Management Framework (UDMF):** The modern, cross-platform solution that is the standard for all new Workday customers. It is driven by highly configurable rules and operates across the entire Workday platform, including HCM, Recruiting, and Student.

2. Legacy Duplicate Management Framework (Match & Merge)

- **Status:** Deprecated for new customers; supported only for existing customers who have not yet migrated to UDMF. It is considered a technical debt, and Workday's direction is for all customers to move to UDMF.

This framework is aptly described as a "black box" solution. This means the logic for identifying duplicates is owned and maintained by Workday, is not transparent to the customer, and cannot be modified. While it provided a basic level of duplicate detection, its rigidity, narrow scope, and lack of configurability are significant limitations in a modern, complex data environment.

2.1 How it Works: The "Hard-Coded" Logic

The legacy system's process is rigid and sequential. It identifies potential duplicates by scanning incoming records against the existing candidate and prospect pool using a fixed set of criteria. A match is flagged only if **both** of the following conditions are met:

1. **Name Match:** The logic is based on a partial match of the name: **First Name Initial + Last Name**. For example, a new candidate named "John Smith" would be flagged as a potential duplicate of existing candidates named "Jane Smith," "Jim Smith," or "Jonathan Smith."
2. **Contact Match:** In addition to the name match, at least one of the following contact methods must also be an exact match:
 - Email Address
 - Phone Number
 - Social Network Account

This created a high volume of "false positives" (e.g., flagging two different J. Smiths as duplicates) while potentially missing more nuanced true duplicates.

2.2 Key Characteristics and Limitations

Understanding the specific limitations of the legacy framework is key to understanding the value of migrating to UDMF.

- **Referrals and Partial Matching:** The framework's support for partial name matching on referrals was intended to be helpful (e.g., catching "Jon" when "Jonathan" exists). However, without the ability to add other criteria, this often led to incorrect matches and required significant manual review by recruiters.
- **The Silo Effect (Critical Limitation):** The scope of the legacy framework is its most significant drawback. It is strictly limited to the **Recruiting** module. This means it can only identify a new candidate as a potential duplicate of another **Candidate** or **Prospect**. It is completely blind to other critical person types in the tenant, such as:
 - **Former Workers:** The system cannot identify that a new applicant is a rehired.
 - **Active Workers:** It cannot identify an internal employee who has incorrectly applied via the external career site.
 - **Students (if applicable):** It cannot connect a candidate record to an existing student record.
- **Manual, Inefficient Resolution:** The user experience for resolving duplicates is entirely manual and inefficient.
 - Recruiters must proactively run the **Find Duplicates for Candidate** report.
 - There are no mass-action capabilities. Each pair of potential duplicates must be reviewed and merged individually.
 - There is no centralized, task-based queue for a data stewardship team to manage. The responsibility falls to individual recruiters, leading to inconsistent data hygiene.
- **Irreversible Merges:** Merges performed using the legacy framework are **permanent**. There is no "unmerge" button or process. An incorrect merge requires significant manual effort to correct and can lead to permanent data loss on the secondary record.

2.3 Configuration

Configuration for the legacy framework is exceptionally limited, which is a primary driver for its future deprecation.

- Administrators can use the **Edit Tenant Setup - Recruiting** task to control a few high-level behaviors. These are simple on/off switches, not configurable logic.
- Examples of these settings include:
 - "Prevent referral if this person already exists for any job requisition or area"
 - "Enable Exact Match for Duplicate Referrals"
- Crucially, these settings only gate the process; they do not alter the fundamental matching algorithm. You cannot add or remove fields from the matching criteria, nor can you change the "First Name Initial + Last Name" logic.

3. Unified Duplicate Management Framework (UDMF)

- **Status:** Default framework for all new customers and the leading practice for all existing customers.

UDMF represents a fundamental shift in approach. It externalizes the matching logic from the application code, empowering administrators to define precisely what constitutes a duplicate for their organization. It is a single, unified framework for the entire Workday platform.

3.1 Core Architecture & Benefits

- **Configurable Match Rules:** Replaces the old hard-coded logic with flexible **Match Rules**. These rules are built using CRFs, which are indexed for performance.
- **Cross-Functional Scope:** A single set of match rules applies to the core **Person** object, enabling the system to identify duplicates across Recruiting (Candidates, Prospects), HCM (Workers, Contingent Workers), and Student.
- **Automatic Merging:** Customers can create "High Confidence" rules (e.g., an exact match on National ID). When a new record meets this criterion, the system can be configured to merge the records automatically, without any manual intervention.
- **Superior Performance:** UDMF is engineered to handle high-volume data processing, making it far more scalable than the legacy framework, especially for organizations with large candidate databases.

3.2 How It Works: The Process Flow

1. **Data Entry:** A new person record enters Workday through any channel (e.g., a candidate applies on the career site, an agency submits a candidate, a recruiter creates a prospect manually).
2. **The "Find Duplicates" Job:** A scheduled background process, the **Find Duplicates Job**, runs to scan the tenant for new records to evaluate against the active **Match Rules**.
3. **Identification & Action:**
 - If a new record triggers a **High Confidence** rule, the system can perform an **Auto-Merge** based on the configuration.
 - If the record triggers a lower-confidence rule for a **Potential Match**, it creates a task that appears in the **Manage Duplicate Records** report.
4. **Resolution:** A designated user (typically in Recruiting or a central Data Governance team) reviews the potential duplicates in the **Manage Duplicate Records** task in their inbox to manually confirm or reject the merge.

3.3 Critical Configuration Steps

To enable UDMF, an administrator must perform the following sequence of tasks:

1. **Opt-In:** Run the **Opt-in to Duplicate Management** task. **This is a critical, functionally irreversible step.** Once you opt-in, you cannot revert to the legacy framework.
2. **Security Update:** Activate and configure the necessary security domains. The primary domains are:
 - **Manage: Duplicate Records**
 - **Set Up: Duplicate Management**
 - It is a leading practice to disable the legacy **Merge Candidate** domain to avoid confusion for end-users.
3. **Define Match Rules:** Run the **Manage Match Rules** task to create the logic that fits your organization's needs. You can create multiple rules with varying levels of confidence.
 - *Example High-Confidence Rule:* (Exact Match on National ID)
 - *Example Potential Match Rule:* (Exact Match on First Name + Last Name) AND (Exact Match on Email Address)
4. **Schedule the Job:** Configure the **Find Duplicates Job** to run on a recurring schedule (e.g., nightly) to consistently identify and process new duplicates.

3.4 Feature-Specific Behaviours

- **Referral Management:** Unlike the legacy framework, UDMF uses **strict matching** for referrals. "Jon" will not match "Jonathan" unless a specific rule, such as one based solely on a matching email address, is met.
- **Agency Candidates:** This is a crucial configuration detail. By default, the **Submit Recruiting Agency Candidate** business process is configured to use the legacy duplicate check. After migrating to UDMF, you **must** edit this business process definition and replace the legacy condition rule with one that uses the UDMF-specific field: **Duplicates Found for the Job Requisition (Recruiting Agency Candidate)**. Failure to do so will cause agency submissions to bypass your configured match rules.
- **Social Media Matching:** UDMF does not support matching on social media accounts. This is a functional regression from the legacy framework that must be considered during the transition.
- **Former Workers:** This is a key area where UDMF provides significant value. It excels at identifying when a new applicant is a former employee. The leading practice is to merge the new candidate record with the former worker record **before** the "Ready for Hire" stage. This ensures the system correctly processes the applicant as a rehire, which preserves their service history and seniority.

4. Migration and Implementation Leading Practices

Migrating from the legacy framework to the Unified Duplicate Management Framework (UDMF) is a significant tenant enhancement. A well-planned approach is critical to its success. The following leading practices provide a detailed roadmap for a smooth transition.

4.1 Audit & Analyze: Establish Your Baseline

Before you can build effective rules, you must first understand the current state of your data. This phase is about quantifying the problem and identifying patterns.

- **Conduct a Quantitative Analysis:**
 - Run the legacy **Find Duplicates for Candidate** report and export the complete results. This is your starting data set.
 - Analyze the volume. Are you dealing with hundreds of duplicates or tens of thousands? This will inform the urgency and resourcing required for the project.
 - Categorize the findings. Group the duplicates by common patterns:
 - **Name Variations:** e.g., "Jon" vs. "Jonathan," hyphenated last names, maiden vs. married names.
 - **Shared Contact Information:** Multiple candidates sharing a single email address or phone number (common in certain industries or with agency submissions).
 - **Former Workers:** Identifying previous employees who are reapplying through the external career site.
 - **Data Entry Errors:** Simple misspellings or typos.
- **Perform a Qualitative Review:**
 - Review a sample of the flagged duplicates with your recruiting team. How many are *true* duplicates versus *false positives*? This will help you understand the accuracy of the legacy logic and the level of manual effort currently being expended.
 - This analysis is not just a technical exercise; it is the foundation upon which your new match rules will be built. The patterns you uncover here will directly translate into the logic you configure in UDMF.

4.2 Define Rules Collaboratively: Build a Cross-Functional Governance Team

Because UDMF is a platform-wide feature, its configuration cannot be done in a silo. The rules you define will impact HCM and potentially Student data, not just Recruiting.

- **Assemble the Stakeholders:**
 - **Recruiting Operations:** They are on the front lines and understand the candidate data and common scenarios.
 - **HRIS / HCM Core Team:** They are the primary owners of the **Worker** record. They must approve any rule that could potentially merge a candidate with a former or current employee to protect data integrity, especially service dates and other core HR data.
 - **Workday Student Team (if applicable):** They have their own critical identifiers and must be involved if student records are in scope.
 - **Integration Team:** They need to be aware of how changes might impact inbound or outbound data flows.
- **Facilitate a Rule-Definition Workshop:**
 - The goal is to define two distinct sets of rules:
 1. **High-Confidence Rules (for Auto-Merging):** These must be rules where there is virtually zero chance of a false positive. The criteria should be based on unique identifiers. A leading practice is to use a combination like **(National ID) AND (Date of Birth)**. The business must agree on what it considers an indisputable match.
 2. **Potential Match Rules (for Manual Review):** These rules are designed to cast a wider net to catch likely duplicates that require human judgment. Examples include **(First Name + Last Name) AND (Email Address)** or **(First Name + Last Name) AND (Phone Number)**.
 - Discuss and document the desired outcome for each rule. Decide which person types (e.g., Active Employees) should be exempt from auto-merging, even if they meet a high-confidence rule.

4.3 Test Thoroughly in Sandbox: Validate Before You Deploy

The opt-in to UDMF is functionally irreversible, making thorough testing in a sandbox environment an absolute necessity.

- **Prepare the Environment:**
 - Insist on using a **recently refreshed sandbox** from a recent copy of your production tenant. Testing match rules against stale or scrambled data is ineffective and will not provide a true picture of how the rules will

behave in production.

- **Develop and Execute Test Cases:**
 - Create a comprehensive set of test scenarios based on the patterns discovered during your audit. For each scenario, create test data (e.g., two separate candidate records) that your rules are designed to catch.
 - **Example Test Cases:**
 - **Former Worker Re-applies:** Create a new external candidate record with data matching a terminated worker in the sandbox.
 - **Email Match:** Create two candidate records with different names but an identical email address.
 - **National ID Match:** Create a candidate record with a National ID that matches an existing record.
 - **Negative Test:** Create a candidate record that is similar to an existing one but should *not* be flagged as a duplicate.
- **Validate the Results:**
 - After creating your test data, manually run the **Find Duplicates Job** in the sandbox.
 - Use the **Manage Duplicate Records** report to verify the outcome. Did your rules flag the correct records? Did the auto-merge rules fire as expected? Were there any unexpected matches or misses?
 - Test the manual merge process using the security roles of the end-users to ensure there are no permission issues.

4.4 Cleanse Data Before Loading: Don't Start with a Backlog

If you are planning to perform a large, one-time data migration of candidates into Workday (e.g., from a legacy ATS), it is a critical leading practice to cleanse this data *before* loading it.

- **Understand the Impact of Bulk Loading Duplicates:** The **Manage Duplicate Records** task is an inbox item for a user to resolve. Loading a file with 10,000 duplicates will generate a backlog of 10,000 tasks in a user's inbox, which is operationally untenable. The system is designed for ongoing hygiene, not massive initial cleanup.
- **Use the Right Tool for the Job:** Use external tools like Excel, data cleansing software, or custom scripts to perform the initial, bulk de-duplication on the source file. This is far more efficient for a one-time event.
- **The Goal:** The objective is to load the cleanest possible data set into Workday, allowing UDMF to effectively manage the *new* duplicates that are created day-to-day through normal operations.

4.5 Plan the Cutover: Execute a Controlled Go-Live

A structured cutover plan minimizes production risk and ensures a smooth transition for users.

- **Develop a Detailed Cutover Checklist:** This should include the precise sequence of events, estimated timing, and the individuals responsible for each step.
- **Sequence of Events:**
 1. **Communication:** Announce the planned change and any brief system downtime to all stakeholders.
 2. **Schedule Window:** Plan the cutover for a period of low system activity, such as a weekend or evening.
 3. **Execute in Production:**
 - Run the **Opt-in to Duplicate Management** task.
 - Configure the **Set Up: Duplicate Management** and **Manage: Duplicate Records** security domains for the appropriate user groups.
 - Manually create the approved **Match Rules** exactly as they were tested and validated in the sandbox.
 - Critically, edit the **Submit Recruiting Agency Candidate** Business Process to replace the legacy duplicate check with the UDMF-specific condition rule.
 - Configure and schedule the **Find Duplicates Job** to run on a recurring basis (typically nightly).
- **Post-Go-Live Monitoring:** For the first few days after go-live, closely monitor the results of the duplicate job and the tasks generated in the **Manage Duplicate Records** report. Be prepared to make minor adjustments to the rules based on real-world results.

5. Frequently Asked Questions

- **Q: Can I use Legacy and UDMF at the same time?**
 - A: No. The **Opt-in to Duplicate Management** task is a binary switch that permanently disables the legacy framework.
- **Q: Why does a Recruiter get a permission error when trying to merge?**
 - A: Merging involves two records. The user performing the merge must have security permissions to view and act upon **both** person records involved in the transaction. For example, to merge a candidate with a former worker, the user needs access to both of those populations.

- **Q: What fields should I use in my Match Rules for the best performance?**
 - A: For optimal performance, build your rules using the dedicated UDMF Class Report Fields (CRFs), such as **Duplicates for Prospect or Job Application**. Avoid using older, legacy fields like **Duplicate Candidates**, as they are not indexed for this purpose and can cause performance degradation.
- **Q: We've configured an auto-merge rule, but it doesn't seem to be working. Why would an automatic merge fail?**
 - A: An automatic merge will only occur under very specific, "safe" conditions. The system is designed to be conservative to prevent incorrect merges. An auto-merge will be prevented if:
 - The specific **Match Rule** is not configured to allow automatic merging.
 - The incoming record matches **more than one** existing person record. The system will not guess; it will flag it for manual review.
 - The **Person Type** of either the source or target record has been explicitly excluded from automatic merging in the rule configuration.
 - There is an in-progress business process or event associated with either record that must be completed or canceled first.
 - The source person record (the one being merged and deactivated) has an active **Workday Account**. An active user account must be dealt with by an administrator before the records can be merged.
- **Q: Can we merge a new candidate record with an existing active employee who applied externally?**
 - A: Yes, the Unified Duplicate Management Framework supports merging a candidate with an active employee. However, a common point of failure occurs if the candidate record already has a **Pre-Hire** record associated with it (e.g., from a previous, abandoned hiring process). The system views this as a **Pre-Hire to Active Employee** merge, which is not a supported combination. **Fix:** To resolve this, you must first use the **Delete Pre-Hires** task to remove the pre-hire record associated with the candidate. Once deleted, the system will correctly see it as a Candidate-to-Employee merge, which can then be completed.
- **Q: What happens if we merge two records by mistake? Can we undo it?**
 - A: Yes, UDMF includes a powerful **Unmerge** capability. Using the **Manage Merged Records** report, you can find previously merged records and initiate an unmerge action. This will separate the two records, and Workday will attempt to restore the data to the respective records as it was pre-merge. This is a significant advantage over the legacy framework, which had no unmerge functionality. However, this action should be performed with caution and a clear understanding of the data involved.
- **Q: After migrating to UDMF, our old 'Duplicate Candidates' report seems inaccurate. Is this expected?**
 - A: Yes, this is expected. The reports and report fields designed for the legacy framework are not compatible with UDMF. After migrating, you must transition all duplicate management reporting and processes to use the new, dedicated reports and objects.
 - **Primary Report:** Use the **Manage Duplicate Records** report as the new source of truth for identifying and resolving potential duplicates.
 - **Report Fields:** When creating calculated fields for alerts (e.g., a 'Duplicate' icon on the candidate grid), do not use the old **Duplicates Found** boolean field. Instead, use the newer, UDMF-specific report fields like **Duplicates Found For Recruiting Event** to ensure your reports are referencing the results of your configured match rules.
- **Q: Does the duplicate check happen in real-time when a recruiter manually creates a prospect?**
 - A: This is a key distinction in how the framework operates. The comprehensive, powerful matching based on your configured **Match Rules** is primarily handled by the **Find Duplicates Job**, which runs on a scheduled basis. However, certain UI tasks like **Create Prospect** have a built-in, *real-time* duplicate check to provide immediate feedback to the user. This real-time check uses its own simplified, hard-coded logic (looking for matches on the data being entered) and does *not* use your configured match rules. Therefore, it should be seen as a first line of defense, with the scheduled job being the authoritative process.

No labels